

# MAINS MASTER PROGRAM (MMP) 2024

## International Relations-2

### Bilateral Relations

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### Previous Years' Questions

1. "Increasing cross-border terrorist attacks in India and growing interference in the internal affairs of member-states by Pakistan are not conducive for the future of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)." Explain with suitable examples. (2016)
2. Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples. (2015).

Most challenging relationship.

Relationship explained as **Paired Minority Conflict** (Stephen P Cohen) and **Brother Enemy** (Shashi Tharoor).

Three full-fledged wars in 1948, 1965, 1971 and a limited war in 1999.

### Bilateral trade:

In 2014-15, highest at \$2.49 billion, with India enjoying significant surplus. Pakistan has banned the bilateral trade since amendment of status of Jammu and Kashmir by Indian Parliament. However, it has permitted the import of life-saving drugs from India. In 2022, the bilateral trade was around \$2.5 billion.

In October 2023, inflation in Pakistan was 31%. Thus, it needs trade with India to cool down the inflation. In March 2024, **Pakistan Finance Minister** said that "Pakistan would look seriously into matters of trade with India." However, there have been no formal requests.

### Demerits of Trade ban:

- Limited impact on India, since It is a much bigger economy with diversified trade partners.

### Impact on Pakistan

1. Goods have to be rerouted through UAE which increases the cost.
2. This has resulted in high inflation in Pakistan and drain of foreign exchange.
3. Increased input cost for Pakistani companies that are dependent on Indian raw materials, rendering them uncompetitive in global trade.

Thus, opening of trade will be more beneficial to Pakistan than to India.

### Challenges in trade resumption:

1. Lack of political will on both sides due to respective constituencies.
2. Pakistan's demand for reversal of dilution of article 370, which is unacceptable to India.
3. Lack of demand in Pakistan- Annual car sale in Pakistan is little over 30,000 while it is 11,000 in India per day.
4. Uncertainties in trade: Any misadventure from Pakistan, and trade might come to abrupt halt.

5. Pakistan has limited ability to pay in US dollars due to foreign exchange crisis and Indian exporters have no use of Pakistani rupee.
6. Both sides issue limited number of visas to each other. Thus, easy movement of businessmen will remain a challenge.
7. Pakistan has very little to offer to India in economic terms. There are also associated security risks.

### Key areas of dispute:

#### Kashmir:

1. After partition, **Maharaja Hari Singh**, the king of erstwhile Jammu and Kashmir decided not to join either India or Pakistan. The king signed **standstill agreement** with Pakistan while India called for further negotiations.
2. Pakistan attacked Jammu and Kashmir on 6 October 1947 in the guise of tribal militia supported by Pakistan army.
3. Maharaja Hari Singh asked India for military assistance and signed **Instrument of Accession** on 26 October 1947.
4. On 1 January 1948, India took the matter to the **United Nations Security Council** for resolution. **UN Commission for India and Pakistan (UNCIP)** was setup. **UNSC resolution 47** called for immediate ceasefire and a plebiscite to decide the fate of Kashmir.



The Resolution recommended a **three-step process** for the resolution of the dispute.

- In the first step, Pakistan was asked to withdraw all its nationals that entered Kashmir for the sake of fighting.
- In the second step, India was asked to progressively reduce its forces to the minimum level required for law and order.
- In the third step, India was asked to appoint a plebiscite administrator nominated by the United Nations who would conduct a free and impartial plebiscite.

The constitution of Jammu and Kashmir was adopted on 17 November 1956, and came into effect on 26 January 1957. It was rendered infructuous on 5 August 2019.

In 1972, following the India-Pakistan War of 1971, Both nations signed the **Shimla Agreement**, agreeing to resolve all their differences through bilateral negotiations.

### Significance of Kashmir:

- **Ideologically:** Linked to two-nation theory and Muslim-majority identity of Kashmir.
- **Geographically:** Sandwiched between China and Pakistan.
- **Economically:** Water resources because Indus Rive System passes through the region and Pakistan's agrarian economy is dependent on it.
- Pakistan Army has continued its control over Pakistan population on the ground of taking back Kashmir from India. They term Kashmir as the "jugular vein of Pakistan".

All the wars between India and Pakistan had Kashmir as a factor.

On 05<sup>th</sup> 2019, India amended Ar. 370 and divided the state of Jammu and Kashmir into two Union territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh. After that, Pakistan suspended bilateral trade, banning all imports and exports to and from India. It has asked India to resume the special status of Jammu and Kashmir. Pakistan has also been raking up Kashmir issue at various international fora, but of limited avail.

### Siachen

Both India and Pakistan claimed some sovereignty over entire region due to lack of clarity beyond point NJ9842. In 1984, India launched **Operation Meghdoot** to take control of Siachen Glaciers. India had pre-empted Pakistan's **Operation Ababeel** by just one day to occupy the heights on **Saltoro Ridge**.

Both nations have tried to arrive at resolution multiple times but failed due to lack of mutual trust. While Pakistan demands the glacier to be demilitarised first, the Indian army demands authentication of the positions first.





### Significance of Siachen Glacier:

- **Location:** Strategically located at height with Pakistan on one side and China on the other side.
- It overlooks Gilgit-Baltistan region of PoK, giving strategic advantage to India in times of war.
- It guards the routes leading to Leh, the capital city of Ladakh.
- It overlooks and dominates the **Shaksgam Valley**, which was illegally ceded to China by Pakistan.
- It is close to the **Karakoram Pass** through which the **Karakoram Highway** passes connecting Gilgit-Baltistan to Xinjiang Province of China.
- **Water resources:** Sources of multiple rivers for irrigation and hydro-power purpose. Nubra river, a tributary of Shyok river, originated from the glacier.

### Sir Creek

- Sir Creek is a 96-km strip of water disputed between India and Pakistan in the Rann of Kutch marshlands.
- The dispute lies in the interpretation of the maritime boundary line between Kutch and Sindh. Pakistan claims the entire creek as per paragraphs 9 and 10 of the **Bombay Government Resolution of 1914** signed between then the Government of Sindh and Rao Maharaj of Kutch.
- But India claims that the boundary lies mid-channel as depicted in another map drawn in 1925, and implemented by the installation of mid-channel pillars back in 1924.
- According to international law and the **Thalweg principle**, a boundary can only be fixed in the middle of the navigable channel, which meant that it has to be divided between Sindh and Kutch, and thereby India and Pakistan.
- After the 1965 war, British Prime Minister Harold Wilson successfully persuaded both countries to end hostilities and set up a tribunal to resolve the dispute.
- The verdict of the tribunal came in 1968 which saw Pakistan getting 10% of its claim of 9,000 km (3,500 sq. miles).
- Since 1969, 12 rounds of talks have been held over the issue of Sir Creek, but both sides have denied reaching any solution.



### Significance of Sir Creek:

- It is an important fishing ground and is one of the largest fishing sources in Asia.
- Possibility of presence of oil and gas reserves under the sea shelf of the region. The area is unexplored due to boundary dispute.
- Fishermen frequently crossing to the other side and get caught by the respective navies.

### Indus Water Treaty

- The treaty regulates the use the water available in Indus River and its tributaries. It is considered as one of the most successful water sharing endeavours in the world today.



- The Indus water treaty was brokered by the World Bank and signed in 1960.
- The treaty gives control over the waters of the three eastern rivers Beas, Ravi and Satluj to India, while control over the waters of three western rivers Indus, Chenab and Jhelum to Pakistan.
- India has about **20% of total water** carried by the Indus River System while **Pakistan has 80%**. India is allowed to use 20% water of the western rivers for irrigation, power generation and transport purposes and unlimited use for non-consumptive purpose.
- The treaty granted 3.6 million acre-feet (MAF) of “permissible storage capacity” to India on the western rivers but due to poor water development projects, 2-3 MAF of water easily flows into Pakistan.
- **Permanent Indus Commission** for implementation and management of the treaty and resolution of any dispute.

### Positives of the Treaty:

1. Despite 3 wars, the treaty has been followed by both nations.
2. The treaty is exhibited by the World Bank as most successful example of resolution of Interstate River water dispute.

3. It also displays India's commitment to international agreements and obligations.

#### Issues:

1. India has about 20% of the total water carried by the Indus system while Pakistan has 80%. It is among the most unequal treaties.
2. Despite being the upper riparian state, India is at disadvantage. India itself has huge water scarcity, that can be addressed by utilizing water of the Indus River System.
3. Pakistan has not been able to utilise the water and it gets wasted by flowing into the sea.
4. Pakistan has used the treaty to delay India's hydroelectric power projects like Salal and Baglihar.
5. Jammu and Kashmir has complained about the lack of water and its irrigation needs. In 2003 and 2016, Jammu & Kashmir assembly demanded abrogation and revision of the treaty respectively.
6. Due to climate change (5% decrease in flow since 1960), advancement in water storage and management techniques, expanding agriculture and population, there has been increase in demand of water.
7. Due to Pakistan's continuous involvement in terrorism, there has been a domestic demand to scrap the treaty.

#### India sent notice for amending IWT

- In January 2023, India issued notice to Pakistan for amending the Indus Water Treaty 1960 under **Article XII (3) of the treaty**. This was done after Pakistan unilaterally tried to change the process of resolving disputes between the two sides. In March 2022, at Pakistan's continued insistence, the World Bank initiated actions on both the Neutral Expert and Court of Arbitration processes.

##### Process of Resolution:

- **First Level:** Inform the other party about the planned projects. This is done at the level of **Permanent Indus Commission (PIC)**.
- **Second Level:** World Bank appoints a **neutral expert** to resolve the differences.
- **Third Level:** If differences not resolved, it becomes a dispute and the matter goes to a **Court of Arbitration (CoA)** whose chair is appointed by the World Bank.
- Ar. XII (3): The provisions of the treaty may from time-to-time be modified by a duly ratified treaty concluded for the purpose between the two governments.
- The Notice gives Pakistan 90 days to enter into Inter-governmental negotiations to rectify violations of the treaty. India aims to update the treaty since situation has changed in last 62 years.

Some experts suggest India to unilaterally abrogate the treaty since Pakistan is continuously creating challenges in Indian projects resulting in unnecessary delays and resulting in cost escalation.



### Challenges with unilateral abrogation of the treaty:

- Abrogation might be difficult, mainly due to India's international obligations and treaties.
- India has not utilized its full rights either over Eastern or Western Rivers.
- Abrogation might lead to increase in tensions. China can become a party to any future negotiation.
- Other lower riparian neighbours of India like Bangladesh might become anxious.

**Recent Step:** With completion of **Shahpur Kandi barrage**, Water of Ravi river has been diverted to benefit Jammu and Kashmir and Punjab, preventing flow of any water through Ravi river to Pakistan.

### Terrorism:

#### Timeline:

1. Use of tribals along with its army in 1947-48.
2. Sneaking in its forces during 1965 to create discontent in the valley for uprising.
3. Use of Mujaheddin in Afghanistan to defeat USSR. Then same technique used to destabilise and internationalise Kashmir since 1990s.

### Bleed India with a thousand cuts:

In a 1965 speech to the UN Security Council, **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto**, the then Foreign Minister of Pakistan, declared a **thousand-year war against India**. Pakistani Army Chief **General Zia-ul-Haq** gave form to Bhutto's "thousand years war" with the '**bleeding India through a thousand cuts**' doctrine using covert and low-intensity warfare with militancy and infiltration. This doctrine was first attempted during the Punjab insurgency and then in Kashmir insurgency using India's western border with Pakistan. India's borders with Nepal and Bangladesh have also been used as points to insert trained militants into the country.

### Attempts at dispute resolution:

**Shimla Agreement:** To reverse the consequences of the 1971 war and a comprehensive blue print for good neighbourly relations between India and Pakistan.

- A mutual commitment to the peaceful resolution of all issues through direct bilateral approaches.
- To build the foundations of a cooperative relationship with special focus on people-to-people contacts.
- To uphold the inviolability of the Line of Control in Jammu and Kashmir, which is a most important CBM between India and Pakistan, and a key to durable peace.

### Composite Bilateral Dialogue:

In 1998, a Composite Dialogue with eight subjects was started between India and Pakistan. This was the first-time reference of "all outstanding issues including Jammu and Kashmir" was mentioned. 1999 - Then prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee visited Lahore, where **Lahore declaration** was signed. Mutual understanding was reached towards the development of atomic arsenals and to avoid accidental and unauthorised operational use of nuclear weapons.

**Agra Summit:** At the meeting, a proposal was made to drastically reduce nuclear arsenals and to resolve other issues involving the Kashmir dispute, and cross-border terrorism. However, the negotiations broke down and the process was collapsed so the Agra treaty was never signed. Sushma Swaraj said it failed as Musharraf was adamant on discussing Kashmir issue first.

In December 2015, both nations agreed to start **Comprehensive Bilateral Dialogue** on issues including Peace and Security, CBMs, Jammu & Kashmir, Siachen, Sir Creek, Wullar Barrage/Tulbul Navigation Project, Economic and Commercial Cooperation, Counter-Terrorism, Narcotics Control, Humanitarian Issues, People to People exchanges and religious tourism.

Currently, the dialogue process is in limbo since India has clearly said that **talks and terror cannot go together**. It has asked for Pakistan to make the environment conducive for dialogues by preventing cross border terrorism. Since the change in status of Jammu and Kashmir, Pakistan has called for revoking the amendment to article 370 for continuation of any bilateral relations.

#### Emerging challenges for India:

1. **China Pakistan Economic Corridor** passing through Pakistan occupied Kashmir increases stake for China to support Pakistan and strengthens China-Pakistan axis.
2. Pakistan has renewed attempts to internationalise Kashmir with support of China.
3. It has gone for adventurism by issuing new maps which includes whole of Jammu and Kashmir and other regions like Junagadh as part of Pakistan.
4. Pakistan economic crisis, political instability, high inflation poses challenge for India as Pakistan may go for miss adventurism at the border to distract the public from domestic issues.
5. Increasing radicalization of Pakistan society, strengthening of groups like **Tahrik-e-labbaik** further pose challenge.
6. China's supply of frigates, fighter jets and other military assets to Pakistan, its port at Gwadar can pose challenge to India's vision of Net Security Provider in the region.
7. **Control of Taliban over Afghanistan**- Pakistan can use Afghanistan to train terrorists and foment trouble in India.
8. Pakistan getting closer to Russia.

#### Scope for Cooperation:

1. **Sanghai Cooperation Organisation:** Since both nations are members of SCO and terrorism & connectivity are its key agendas, both can cooperate under the platform.
2. **Kartarpur Corridor**- Opening of Kartarpur corridor proves possibility of people-to-people engagements reducing bilateral tensions.
3. Agreement on ceasefire at LOC in February 2021
4. Pakistan military chief talking about geoeconomics rather than geopolitics at inaugural Islamabad Security Dialogue
5. Pakistan's recently unveiled National Security Policy has put economic security at the core of comprehensive national security.

6. Pakistan finance Minister has expressed willingness about trade with India. This can result in restart of engagements.

#### **Pakistan's first National Security Policy**

1. On 14 January 2022, Pakistan unveiled Pakistan's first National Security Policy (NSP), which purportedly focuses on the '**security of its citizens.**' It stresses human security, geo-economics, regional connectivity, prosperity, trade, and investment. It gives an impression of fresh new thinking from the Pakistani establishment.
2. It aims to define the country's security priorities between 2022 to 2026, including relations with India.
3. It mentions that 'Pakistan, under its policy of peace at home and abroad, wishes to improve its relationship with India.

At **Islamabad Security Dialogue**, Ex- Army chief General Bajwa talked about shift from geopolitics to geo-economics. He said that Pakistan was keen to 'bury the past and move forward'.

**Attack on Chinese workers:** Attack on Chinese projects and workers has caused strain in all whether China Pakistan friendship. Many Chinese workers have moved back to China due to concern over security.

**Political instability in Pakistan-** The new Shahbaz Sharif government has been accused of coming to power with the support of military. Ex-Pakistan PM Imran Khan has been imprisoned and his party is on the verge of being banned. There are protests in Balochistan (Pashtun Tahaffuz Movement) and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (in favour of Imran Khan). Tahreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) has been challenging the security forces of Pakistan. This has been further complicated by precarious economic situation, high inflation and decline of Pakistani rupee.

#### **Practice Questions:**

1. Analyse the current policy of India towards Pakistan. Suggest a way forward for both nations to ensure lasting peace.
2. Composite bilateral dialogue continues to hold relevance in improving India Pakistan relations. Discuss.
3. The recent change in Pakistan's policy has potential to improve its relations with the neighbours. What can be the possible challenges to it? How should India respond to these challenges?
4. Pakistan's economic Crisis he is both a challenge and opportunity for India. Discuss.
5. Discuss the evolution of India Pakistan policy. Suggest pragmatic ways for resolution of bilateral disputes.
6. Balakot airstrike presents a shift in India's policy towards Pakistan. But it also presents a new set of challenges. Discuss.

## India-Afghanistan relations

### Previous Years' Questions

1. The proposed withdrawal of International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) from Afghanistan in 2014 is fraught with major security implications for the countries of the region. Examine in light of the fact that India is faced with a plethora of challenges and needs to safeguard its own strategic interests. (2013)

### Brief History

- India aided the overthrow of the Taliban by offering intelligence and other forms of support for the Coalition forces led by the USA in 2001.
- After the overthrow of the Taliban, India established diplomatic relations with the newly established democratic government, provided aid and participated in the reconstruction efforts.
- India has made key infrastructure projects like new Afghan parliament, Zaranj- Delaram Highway, Indira Gandhi Hospital, Salma dam (India Afghanistan Friendship dam) and has projects going on in all the 34 provinces.
- India is the biggest regional donor to Afghanistan and fifth largest donor globally with over \$3 billion in assistance. India has built over 200 public and private schools, sponsors over 1,000 scholarships, hosts over 16,000 Afghan students.
- Relations between Afghanistan and India received a major boost in 2011 with the signing of a **Strategic Partnership Agreement**.
- Since coming of Taliban in 2021, the relationship has deteriorated once again. However, in June 2022, India has made its embassy operational through a 'technical team' to support the supply of relief material for helping people suffering from devastating earthquake.
- Taliban regime in Afghanistan has also shown interest in engaging with India, assured of full cooperation and security in Afghanistan and has asked India to resume its developmental projects.

**Trade Relations:** Bilateral trade in 2018-19 was around \$1.5 billion. As a Least Developed Country (LDC) Afghanistan enjoys duty free access to Indian markets for Afghan products like dry fruits. Coming of Taliban has disrupted the trade. However, India has tried to ensure access through Chabahar port. There has been a decline in bilateral trade. Afghanistan's trade with India in 2023 worth \$779 million, with \$579 million in exports and \$200 million in imports

### Challenge

1. Pakistan unwillingness to provide overland route for trade.
2. Increased unpredictability due to security and other concerns since coming of Taliban.
3. Fear of opium trade and narcotics trafficking within the Indian borders.
4. Limited engagement of India with Taliban create challenge for exploitation of abundant iron reserves (Hajigak) and copper deposits (Mes Ayank).



**Security Cooperation:** India provided military training and other platforms like Mi-25 attack helicopters for Afghan forces. Since coming of Taliban, these corporations have been halted. India has started training Afghan diplomats under ITEC programme in online mode.

**Humanitarian Assistance:** Indian efforts included the supply of wheat and commitment to regularly contribute to the Afghan Red Crescent Society for the treatment of Afghan children with congenital heart disease.

**Capacity Building Initiatives:** This was a significant area of Indian assistance to Afghans, and critical initiatives included Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation Programme (ITEC) courses for Afghan Government officials, training via telecommunication at medical facilities, and Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) fellowships for Afghan students.

### Current Challenges

1. After Taliban takeover, India has evacuated its embassies. This has created challenges for the development works undertaken by India in Afghanistan.
2. Taliban takeover also provides ungoverned spaces for the terror groups like Laskar-e- Taiba and Jais-e-Mohammed to train and launch attacks against India.
3. Threat to the minorities in Afghanistan have created refugee crisis and India had to evacuate Hindu and Sikh minorities in Afghanistan.
4. Taliban's involvement in opium trade may also lead to illegal narcotics trafficking to India. There have been cases of containers filled with opium caught at the Mundra port.
5. Challenges emerging out of humanitarian crisis in Afghanistan, fear of ISIS and other terror groups activities in Afghanistan can destabilise the region as a whole.
6. Greater influence and control of Haggani network in Taliban government and regime limits the scope for trust best relationship between India and Taliban.
7. At the **Delhi Regional Security Dialogue**, absence of Pakistan and China shows unwillingness of both these nations to accept India rule in Afghan affairs and stability.
8. Islamic state is also strengthening itself and is being joined by disgruntled elements of Taliban and Uighur radicals. This can further destabilise Afghanistan and complicate the regional security scenario.

### Positives:

1. India enjoys huge soft power and acceptability among all Afghan tribes and common population.
2. India's development projects have brought noticeable difference to the life of common Afghans and Indian projects are ongoing in all the Afghan provinces. Taliban has asked India to complete the projects and has promised security to them.
3. India has provided food, vaccine and medical aid to Afghan people. India has formally engaged with Taliban through its Doha office.
4. India also organised Delhi Regional Security Dialogue which saw attendance of NSAs of Afghanistan's neighbours including Russia and Iran. However, Pakistan and chinaware conspicuous absentees.

5. Iran has affirmed India's stake in the stability of Afghanistan during Delhi Regional Security Dialogue.
6. Activation of Chabahar port and start of trade with Afghanistan and other Central Asian Republics through Chabahar provide opportunity for continued economic engagement.

#### Recent Initiatives:

1. India has engaged with Taliban through its Doha office. Taliban has also showed eagerness towards Indian investment in Afghanistan and ask for India to continue them.
2. India has provided medical supplies and food to Afghanistan in the form of humanitarian assistance.
3. It has also organised meeting of NSAs under **Delhi Regional Security Dialogue on Afghanistan** to discuss the challenges emerging out of Taliban takeover of Afghanistan.
4. It has increased its engagement at highest level with Central Asian republics through **India-Central Asia summit**.
5. In early March 2024, Indian delegation from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) visited Kabul and held meetings with the senior members of the Afghanistan administration.

#### Key points of Delhi Declaration:

1. Afghanistan's territory should not be used for sheltering, training, planning or financing of any terrorist acts.
2. There should be cooperation against the menace of radicalisation, extremism, separatism and drug trafficking in the region.
3. There should be an open and truly inclusive government that represents the will of the people of Afghanistan.
4. The United Nations has a central role to play in Afghanistan, its continued presence must be preserved.
5. Ensuring that the fundamental rights of women, children and minority communities are not violated.

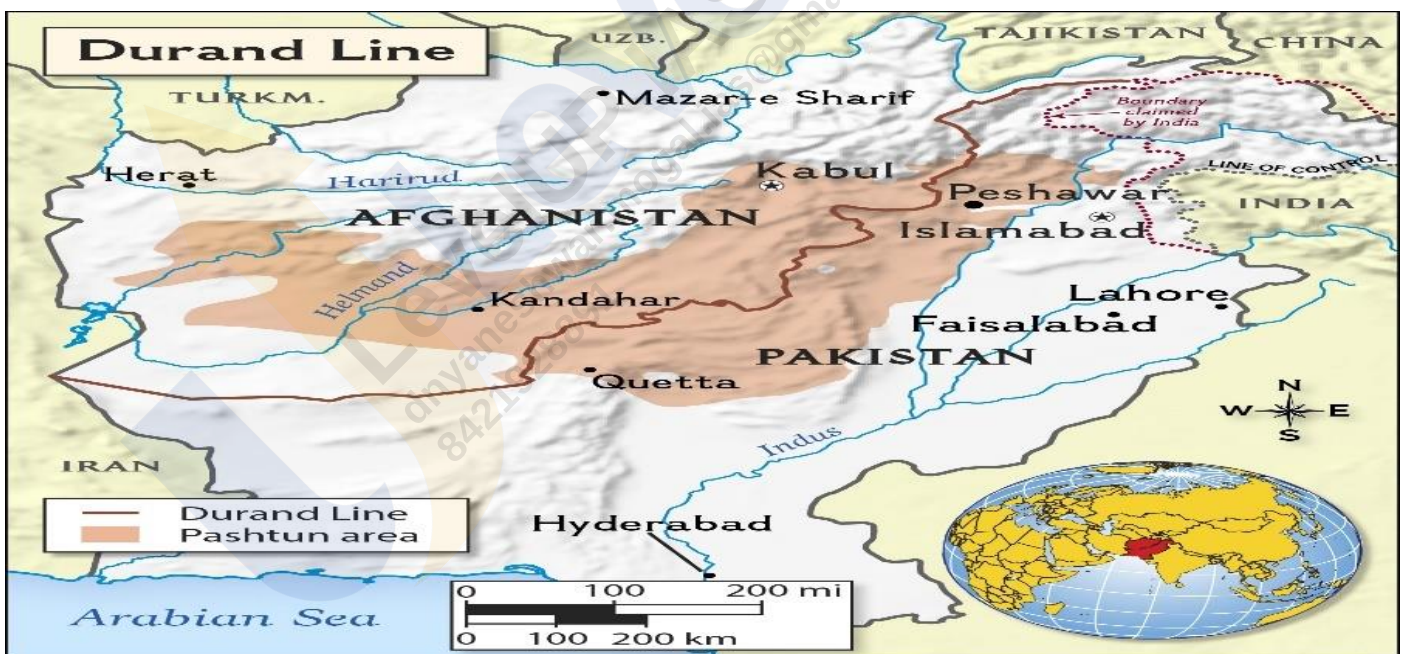
#### Pakistan Taliban Tensions

1. Pakistan has tried to fence the borders in order to prevent the cross-border movement of TTP. Taliban is against any such fencing and hasn't recognised **Durand Line**.
2. Despite its support in driving USA out, Pakistan hasn't been of much help to Taliban. It hasn't recognised the Taliban regime as well.
3. Taliban also sees Pakistan's support to USA for drone operations within Afghanistan, that killed Al-Qaeda leader Zawahiri.
4. There are also reports of Pakistan supporting ISKP against Taliban to pressurise them.
5. Pakistan has also taken military actions withing Afghan border, that has not gone well with Taliban regime.
6. **Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP)** has continued to attack the Pakistan military and conduct explosions in various parts of Pakistan. Afghan Taliban has not brought TTP to the negotiating table. It has shrugged off its responsibility.

7. There have been attacks on Pakistan embassy in Afghanistan and also on the Chinese embassy.
8. Taliban has also been engaging with India that is not liked by Pakistan.

#### Afghanistan-Pakistan Border Issue:

- **Durand Line** was established in **1893** as the border between British India and Pakistan. After partition and independence, the line became border between Afghanistan and Pakistan.
- The area cuts through the Pashtun tribal areas, Balochistan region dividing ethnic Pashtuns, Balochs and other ethnic groups.
- Though the border is internationally recognized, Afghanistan has never recognized it. Neither Hamid Karzai nor Ashraf Ghani nor Taliban regime have recognized the border.
- Article 2 of the Durand Line Agreement which states "The Government of India will at no time exercise interference in the territories lying beyond this line on the side of Afghanistan ". But Pakistan has continuously tried to interfere in Afghan politics to have a pliant regime in Afghanistan.
- Neither the previous Taliban regime nor the present one has recognized the border. They have argued that there should be no borders among Muslims.
- The terrain is mountainous. The area is hideout of Tahrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) that fights against the Pakistan government and demands implementation of Sharia law in Pakistan.
- This time, Pakistan expected that due to its help, Taliban will recognize the Durand Line, bringing TTP to the negotiating table and conflict will end. But that did not happen.



#### China factor

- Taliban has shown greater interest in engaging with China. China-Pakistan axis makes it more convenient for China to engage with Afghanistan. This would limit the diplomatic space available for India.

- While China hasn't formally recognized the Taliban government, They received the Taliban ambassador and allowed them to control Afghanistan's embassy in Beijing. In September 2023, China's new ambassador presented credentials to the acting Taliban Prime Minister.
- China has talked about extending BRI to Afghanistan. In August 2023, Taliban regime Deputy Prime Minister Maulawi Abdul Kabir affirmed their support for the BRI and "practical cooperation" with China.
- China is also interested in vast untapped mineral wealth in Afghanistan. Chinese business community has visited Afghanistan to invest in rich mineral resources. In December 2022, China implemented zero tariffs on 98% of Afghan products.
- in January 2023, the Taliban signed a \$540 million contract to extract oil from northern Afghanistan's Amu Darya basin. In April 2023, the Taliban Ministry of Mines and Petroleum announced that a Chinese company was interested in investing \$10 Billion in Lithium and another rare earth mineral.
- By engaging with Taliban, China can limit the influence of ETIM and other Uighur militants from destabilizing Xinjiang.
- China has also facilitated trilateral talks with Afghanistan and Pakistan aimed at preventing any souring of relations between the Taliban and Pakistan especially regarding TTP.

**Challenge for China:** Presence of Uighurs in ISIS ranks present threat to the Chinese projects and personnel in both Afghanistan and Pakistan.

**Russia:** Russia has allowed the Taliban to manage Afghanistan's embassy in Moscow. But in April 2023, Russia held regional consultations for peace in Afghanistan, excluding the Taliban, while inviting other regional actors. Russian officials' statements urge the Taliban to form ethnically and gendered inclusive governments. Additionally, the horrific terrorist attack on the Crocus concert hall in Moscow, claimed by the **Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP)** active in Afghanistan, strained relations.

**United States** and the **European Union** have not allowed the Taliban to assume control over Afghanistan's embassies within their territories. The Taliban regime's lack of alignment with international norms on human rights and women's rights remains a significant point of contention.

#### Practice Questions:

1. Recent changes in Afghanistan pose multidimensional challenges to India. How has India tried to tackle those challenges?
2. Taliban in Afghanistan is both challenge and opportunity for India. Discuss.
3. Assess the evolution of India's Afghanistan policy. Analyse the recent initiatives undertaken by India with respect to Afghanistan.
4. India's Afghanistan policy has seen a shift from idealism to pragmatism. Discuss.
5. Afghanistan presents an opportunity for cooperation between India and China. Discuss the challenges involved and suggest a way forward.



## India-China Relations

### Previous Years' Questions

1. The USA is facing an existential threat in the form of a China, that is much more challenging than the erstwhile Soviet Union." Explain. Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India? (2021)
2. The newly tri-nation partnership AUKUS is aimed at countering China's ambitions in the Indo-Pacific region. Is it going to supersede the existing partnerships in the region? Discuss the strength and impact of AUKUS in the present scenario. (2021)
3. 'China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbour. (2017)

Five principles of Panchsheel were enunciated in 1954 agreement were:

1. Mutual respect for each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty,
2. Mutual non-aggression,
3. Mutual non-interference,
4. Equality and mutual benefit, and
5. Peaceful co-existence.

### Key agreements with China

1. The **Border Peace and Tranquility Agreement** signed by China and India in September 1993, agreeing to maintain the status quo on their mutual border pending an eventual boundary settlement.
2. The **Agreement on Military Confidence Building Measures**, 1996, pursuant to the 1993 agreement, incrementally details the military confidence building measures to be implemented that would ensure no-war.
3. The Protocol for the Implementation of **Military Confidence Building Measures**, 2005 further discussed modalities to implement the confidence building measures.
4. **Border Defence Cooperation Agreement (BDCA)** in 2013 covers border stability and security, information asymmetry, smuggling, socio-economic reconstruction, environment and disease transmission along the line of actual control.

2013- Depsang Standoff, 2017- Doklam Crisis, 2020 Galwan Clashes have resulted in severe deterioration in bilateral relations.

### Significance of China:

1. India's largest neighbour with longest unresolved borders
2. Among India's largest trade partners. In 2023-24, China was India's largest trade partner with bilateral trade of \$118.4 billion.
3. Increasing Chinese footprints in South Asia presents challenge for India
4. Adversarial neighbour with history of conflict



5. Most important ally and supporter of Pakistan, helping it at various fora including UNSC.
6. No Limits Partnership with Russia.
7. Top trading partner of more than 120 countries.
8. Most of supply chains are China-linked
9. Permanent members of UNSC
10. Second largest economy and third strongest military
11. Revisionist Power
12. Misadventurism in Indo-Pacific with island building and militarisation of South China Sea

### Economic Relations:

**Bilateral Trade:** More than \$118.4 billion (2023-24) with a deficit of over \$80 billion. Chinese exports to India were at \$101.7 billion and imports from India at \$16.67 billion.

Officially, China's FDI in India stands at over \$2.34 billion. A report titled “**Chinese Investments in India**” by Gateway House estimated that the total value of Chinese investments in Indian start-ups between 2015 to 2020 is approximately US \$4 billion. In fact, as of March 2020, 18 out of 30 Indian unicorns were heavily backed by Chinese investments. But since April 2020, less than a quarter of 435 FDI applications have been approved.

In April 2020, India tweaked its FDI policy making its mandatory for entities from countries sharing borders with India can invest only under the “Government route”. As per experts, this was indirectly aimed at China, to curb opportunistic takeovers/acquisitions of Indian companies due to Covid-19 pandemic. In the last three years, India has received a **little less than \$10 billion from mainland China. There has been increased opacity in Chinese investments.**

### Key Challenges:

1. High trade deficit- Crossed \$100 billion in FY23.
2. Barriers for Indian companies in entering Chinese markets.
3. Nature of relationship- India supplier of raw material and China supplier of finished goods
4. Fear of data security and Chinese spying
5. Concerns about weaponisation of trade
6. Absence of reciprocity from China
7. Substandard products and loss to Indian manufacturers
8. China's aggressive posturing at the borders

### Recent Initiatives:

1. **Atmanirbhar Bharat** to reduce import dependence and boost exports by giving a push for domestic manufacturing.
2. **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative** to diversify and de-risk supply chains.
3. **Banning of Chinese apps:** More than 200 apps have been banned on the ground of posing threat to privacy and security of India.
4. In April 2020, prior government approval needed for investment from countries that share land border with India.

5. After June 15, telecom companies can only buy certain types of equipment from government-approved "trusted sources".
6. **Production-linked incentive (PLI)** scheme- in bulk drugs, mobile manufacturing etc.
7. From November 1, 2023, it will restrict the import of laptops, computers, and their components without a license. However, the government has allowed restriction-free imports but launched a new system of "authorisation" aimed at monitoring shipments of such hardware without hurting market supply.

The **Economic Survey 2023-24** has said that allowing foreign direct investment (FDI) from China could help boost India's exports to the western nations.

#### Security cooperation:

- An agreement on security cooperation between the ministry of home affairs of India and the ministry of public security of China to strengthen and consolidate discussions and cooperation in the areas of counter-terrorism, organized crimes, drug control and other such relevant areas.
- **Hand in Hand exercise**- India-China joint military exercise to enhance interoperability between the two armies to counter-terrorism.

#### Challenges in Security Domain:

- Border dispute between two nations and China's salami slicing technique.
- China preventing designations of terrorists at the UNSC under 1267 sanctions committee. In June 2023, China blocked Indian proposal to designate Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorist Sajid Mir as a global terrorist for his involvement in the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks.
- China's support to Pakistan and challenges of a two-front war.
- Concerns about China's support to the insurgents in the North-east. Centre informed UAPA tribunal that Paresh Barua led ULFA (I) is based in Yunnan province in China.

#### Steps Taken

1. Mirror deployments along Ladakh border.
2. Rapid infrastructure upgradation along Norther border along with acquisition of key Platforms like fighter jets, UAVs etc, for surveillance.
3. Indian Army has carried a major reorientation towards the LAC, under which several formations facing the western front were re-tasked to the LAC, in the backdrop of heightened Chinese activity across the LAC.
4. India and Japan have agreed to upgrade the 2008 joint declaration on security cooperation to be responsive to current security challenges.
5. India has also participated in QUAD and expanded Malabar exercise.

## Positions on Border Dispute

### India's Position:

Dr Jaishankar has said that the state of the border will determine the state of the India-China relationship. For ties to return to a positive trajectory and remain sustainable, they must be based on the three mutuals – mutual sensitivity, mutual respect, and mutual interest.

### China's Position:

The two countries “should take a long-term view, place the border issue in an appropriate position in bilateral relations, and promote the transition of the border situation to normalized engagement.”

## China-Indian Ocean Region Forum

In November 2022, China convened a first “**China-Indian Ocean Region Forum**” bringing together 19 countries from the region – and all of India's neighbours, except for India. It brought together representatives from countries including Indonesia, Pakistan, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Maldives, Nepal, Afghanistan, Iran, Oman, South Africa, Kenya, Mozambique, Tanzania, Seychelles, Madagascar, Mauritius, Djibouti, and Australia.

- I. China “proposed to establish a marine disaster prevention and mitigation cooperation mechanism between China and countries in the Indian Ocean region, and stood ready to provide necessary financial, material, and technical support to countries in need”.
- II. China also “proposed the establishment of a blue economy think tank network for China and countries in the Indian Ocean region with the support of Yunnan.”

## Avenues of Cooperation:

1. Membership of multiple platforms like BRICS, SCO etc.
2. Common position on WTO reforms
3. Common position Climate change negotiations
4. A more fair and just global governance through World Bank and IMF reforms.
5. Tackling terrorism which presents threat to both India and China.
6. Energy security- Scope for R&D in the field of green energy.
7. Achieving sustainable development goals.

## Areas of divergence:

1. Border disputes
2. Trade imbalance- India has continuously complained about lack of access to Chinese markets.
3. River water cooperation over Brahmaputra Rive and China's dam building.
4. Future of Dalai Lama
5. South China sea
6. Differences over Indo-pacific and QUAD
7. Vision about order in Asia and global order
8. Differing positions on Belt and road initiative
9. Support to Pakistan Vs. India USA partnership

10. China's debt trap diplomacy particularly in India's neighbourhood
11. India's membership to various platforms like UNSC and NSG.
12. China has put hold multiple times on listing proposals to designate Pakistan-based terrorists under the 1267 Al Qaeda Sanctions Committee regime.

#### China in South Asia:

- China's total debt to Pakistan is more than \$77 billion, around 1/3<sup>rd</sup> of Pakistan's total debt. Sri Lanka owes \$7.4 billion, around 20% of Sri Lanka's total debt.
- China and Nepal agreed to build the **Trans-Himalayan Multi-Dimensional Connectivity Network** or **Trans-Himalayan network**, as part of Belt and Road initiative.
- China "will not join" the official creditors' platform negotiating a common debt treatment plan with Sri Lanka. It also didn't come forward for helping Sri Lanka during its severe economic crisis.
- **Himalayan QUAD:** China working along with Nepal, Pakistan and Afghanistan.
- **Bhutan:** China and Bhutan have agreed on a Three-step roadmap for expediting the boundary negotiations to settle border dispute.

#### Border Disputes



#### Packaged Solution:

China made the so-called "package" offer in 1960 and in 1980–85 where it suggested to accept an alignment in the Eastern Sector, in general conforming to the McMahon Line, but India would have to concede Aksai Chin to China in the Western Sector.

In 1985 China made modifications to the package— "the Indian side would have to make significant and meaningful concessions in the Eastern Sector... for which China would make corresponding but

undefined concessions in the Western Sector". Additionally, Tawang was brought up "as indispensable to any boundary settlement". These changes in the package proposal by China remained till at least 2015.

#### **Possible factors behind ongoing border dispute:**

1. India's infrastructure build-up in the region.
2. To divert attention from internal discontent
3. Response to India's involvement in Doklam
4. Response against increasing India's proximity to the west.
5. Send a message to India and the region
6. Change in status of Ladakh

#### **South China Sea**

**Recent Updates:** India has exported Brahmos Missile System to Philippines. In March 2024, during his visit to Manila, Dr. S. Jaishankar articulated India's full support for the Philippines in upholding its national sovereignty. A joint statement in 2023 between New Delhi and Manila had also called for China to adhere to the rules-based maritime order and acknowledge the International Court of Justice ruling of 2016 in favour of Manila.

Chinese Navy has been regularly harassing Philippines naval ships in the South China Sea. There have been violent clashes between both navies. India has said that it opposes unilateral actions seeking to change the status quo by force in South China.

#### **Significance:**

1. The U.S. Geological Survey estimates that the sea contains as much as 290 trillion cubic feet of natural gas.
2. The South China Sea also accounts for about one-tenth of the entire annual global fish catch.
3. Strategic Importance: This sea is the connecting link between the Indian Ocean and the Pacific Ocean (Strait of Malacca).
4. one-third of the global shipping passes through South China Sea

#### **Contesting Claims Over Islands:**

1. The Paracel Islands are claimed by China, Taiwan and Vietnam.
2. The Spratly Islands are claimed by China, Taiwan, Vietnam, Brunei and Philippines.
3. The Scarborough Shoal is claimed by Philippines, China and Taiwan.



## China's Assertion: Nine-dash Line



## Belt and Road Initiative

China's Belt and Road Initiative is a global infrastructure development strategy adopted by the Chinese government in 2013 to invest in nearly 70 countries and international organizations. It is a strategy initiated by the People's Republic of China that seeks to connect Asia with Africa and Europe via land and maritime networks with the aim of improving regional integration, increasing trade and stimulating economic growth.



By the end of 2016, more than 100 countries had expressed their support for and willingness to participate in the building of the BRI project, and 39 countries and international organizations have signed 46 agreements with China for this. By the end of 2021, 142 countries had signed a cooperation agreement with China to work under the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative. In total, China has already spent an estimated \$200 billion on such efforts. Morgan Stanley has predicted China's overall expenses over the life of the BRI could reach \$1.2–1.3 trillion by 2027, though estimates on total investments vary.

**Present Status:** The project is facing challenges. Reports show that China's infrastructure activities under the Belt and Road framework have decreased by 40 percent compared to 2018. China's lending to Africa in 2021 and 2022 was below \$2 billion, a 20-year low. Germany has come out of BRI.

**Significance:**

1. The Asian Development Bank estimated that the region faces a yearly infrastructure financing shortfall of nearly \$800 billion.
2. Bridge the financial gap and supplement institutions like World Bank and Asian development Bank.
3. Create new growth poles and spur investment.
4. Support rapid development of developing nations and least developed countries.
5. Help in swifter global recovery and create demand.
6. Can help in reducing western dominance on global finance.

**Challenges:**

1. Lack of transparency
2. Little concern for environment and labour norms.
3. Lacks involvement of civil society, local groups etc. in decision making in recipient nations.
4. Has led to unsustainable debt burden for on developing nations like Sri Lanka, Kenya etc.
5. Seen as vehicle for China's geopolitical dominance
6. Alternative initiatives by other nations like USA, EU, Japan etc.

**India's criticism:**

1. Violates India's sovereignty and territorial integrity
2. Lacks transparency and accountability
3. May lead to unsustainable debt burden for poor countries of global south.
4. balanced ecological and environmental protection and preservation standards

**Global Response to BRI:**

**USA: Blue Dot Network and BUILD Act**

**Blue Dot Network:** The Blue Dot Network aims to promote quality infrastructure investment that is open and inclusive, transparent, economically viable, Paris Agreement aligned, financially, environmentally and socially sustainable, and compliant with international standards, laws and regulations. To accomplish this, the Blue Dot Network will certify infrastructure projects against robust criteria and standards.

The United States, Australia, and Japan are working with the OECD to develop a methodology and metrics for certification of infrastructure projects based on these principles.

**Build Act:** The Better Utilization of Investments Leading to Development Act (BUILD Act) Aims at facilitating the participation of private sector capital and skills in the economic development of countries with low or lower middle-income economies. It creates US International Development

Finance Corporation (USIDFC) whose role is to facilitate sustainable, broad based economic growth, poverty reduction, and development.

**Japan: Asia-Africa Growth Corridor** - The Asia-Africa Growth Corridor or AAGC is an economic cooperation agreement between the governments of India, Japan and multiple African countries. It is a collaborative effort to promote development, connectivity and cooperation between Asia and Africa as part of a 'liberal and value-based order'.

**European Union: Global Gateway Plan**- Announced by European Commission to mobilise EURO 300 billion by 2027 in public and private infrastructure investment around the world.

**Practice Questions:**

1. Assess the future of China-Russia relationship. What should be India's course of action to protect and further its geopolitical interests?
2. China Russia no limit partnership is a result of circumstances and has its own limitations. Examine. Discuss India's strategy for reinvigorating its ties with Russia.
3. Direction of India-China relationship will determine not only future of Asia, but also the geopolitics of 21<sup>st</sup> century. Critically examine.